

Journal Strategy

Journal tiers, fit, reviewer expectations, target ranking and submission strategy

Machine Learning for Alpha Signal Combination and Portfolio Construction

This report is part of a pre-empirical research proposal. It distinguishes verified evidence, research inference, proposed design choices and hypotheses. No backtest results are reported; expected outcomes are hypotheses.

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Journal Strategy Report

Executive Summary

The paper should be written for a **finance** audience first, with ML and optimisation rigor as supporting strengths. The realistic primary targets are the **Journal of Financial and Quantitative Analysis** and **Management Science (Finance)**. The stretch target is the **Review of Financial Studies**, which has published the closest precedents (Gu, Kelly & Xiu, 2020; DeMiguel et al., 2020; Jensen et al., 2026). Strong alternatives are the Review of Asset Pricing Studies, Review of Finance and Quantitative Finance. Backups are the Journal of Financial Markets, Journal of Banking & Finance and Journal of Empirical Finance. A shorter practitioner version could go to the Financial Analysts Journal or the Journal of Financial Data Science after the main paper is on SSRN.

Metrics note. Clarivate Journal Impact Factors could not be verified from an accessible primary source and are not reported as facts. Instead we report OpenAlex 2-year mean citedness and h-index (pulled from the OpenAlex API, September 2026). This is a transparent, reproducible proxy, not the JIF. Chartered ABS AJG and ABDC grades must be checked on the official lists before use in any internal assessment.

1. Four Kinds of Venue (why Impact Factor alone misleads)

Category	Examples	What they reward	What gets a paper rejected	Implication for us
1. Prestigious general finance	JF, RFS, JFE	A general economic insight that changes how the field thinks; mechanism; very broad robustness	"Better backtest" without economic content; incremental method; weak baselines	Only if the decomposition yields a general lesson about <i>why</i> ML adds value
2. Top field / quantitative finance	JFQA, MS-Finance, RAPS, Review of Finance; QF, JFEc	Rigorous methods with clear financial relevance; narrower contribution acceptable	Snooping, missing costs, poor positioning versus closest papers	Best fit for our design
3. Interdisciplinary ML/OR/forecasting	MS (other departments), OR, EJOR, IJF, JoE, JBES; ICAIF, NeurIPS/ICML workshops	Methodological novelty (often theory or algorithms), finance as application	Weak economic evaluation, especially costs, for finance-facing claims; lack of theory for OR/econometrics	Fits spin-offs (differentiable optimiser; inference methods)
4. Accessible but respectable	JBF, JEF, JFM, JEDC, CFR, FAJ, JPM, JFDS, AOR	Solid execution, practical relevance, clarity	Sloppy integrity; overstated claims	Backups and practitioner dissemination

Impact factor misleads here because high-volume applied-AI journals (e.g., Expert Systems with Applications, OpenAlex 2-yr mean citedness about 7.5) out-cite most specialist finance journals (e.g., JFQA about 3.4) yet carry far less weight with finance hiring and tenure committees and with finance reviewers [[inference based on field norms](#)].

2. Journal Comparison

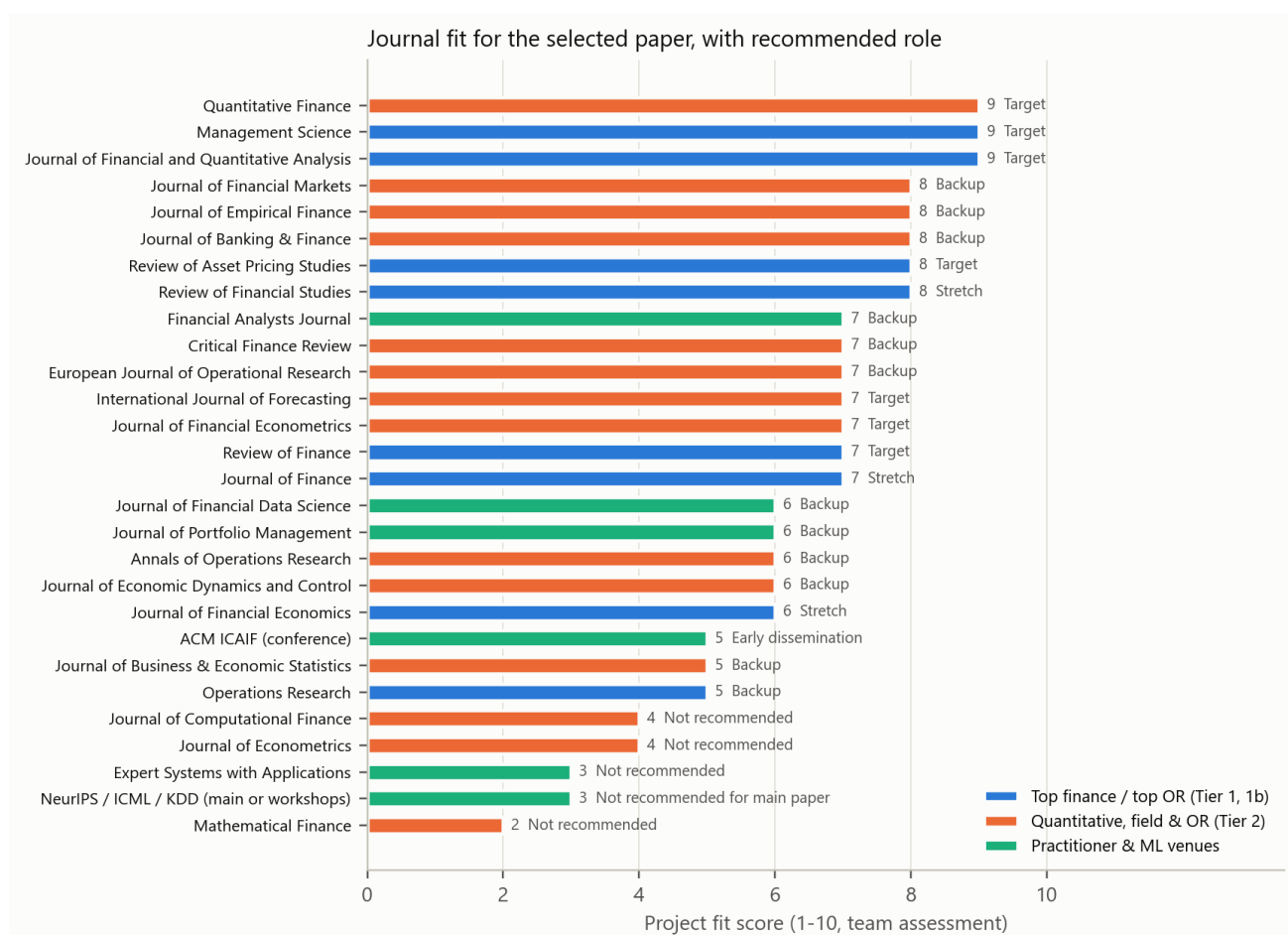


Figure 1. Project fit score (team assessment) by journal, coloured by venue class, with recommended role. OpenAlex metrics and details in Workbook 2.

Journal	Tier	OpenAlex 2y cit. / h	Fit (1-10)	Difficult y (1-5)	Role	Code/data policy
Review of Financial Studies	1	11.8 / 397	8	5	Stretch	Verified: Data Editors; reproducibility package (conditional acceptances from 1 Oct 2025)
Journal of Finance	1	13.2 / 664	7	5	Stretch	Verified: AFA Data and Code Sharing Policy (2024)
Journal of Financial Economics	1	12.4 / 557	6	5	Stretch (lower fit)	Policy page exists
JFQA	1b	3.4 / 255	9	4	Primary target	Verified: code sharing policy page
Management Science (Finance)	1b	6.2 / 480	9	4	Primary target	Verified: Code and Data Disclosure Policy with Data Editor (2019)
Review of Asset Pricing Studies	1b	4.3 / 49	8	4	Target	SFS journal (verify)
Review of Finance	1b	n/a (verify)	7	4	Target	Verified: policy page exists
Quantitative Finance	2	2.5 / 113	9	3	Target	Verify
Journal of Financial Econometrics	2	1.2 / 77	7	4	Target (inference variant)	Verify
International Journal of Forecasting	2	3.8 / 188	7	3	Target (combination variant)	Verify
Journal of Financial Markets	2	2.1 / 104	8	3	Backup	Verify
Journal of Banking & Finance	2	4.4 / 309	8	3	Backup	Verify

Journal	Tier	OpenAlex 2y cit. / h	Fit (1-10)	Difficulty (1-5)	Role	Code/data policy
Journal of Empirical Finance	2	2.8 / 133	8	3	Backup	Verify
European Journal of Operational Research	2	5.9 / 407	7	3	Backup (optimisation variant)	Verify
Critical Finance Review	2	3.7 / 32	7	3	Backup (critical re-assessment)	Verify
Operations Research	1b (OR)	3.5 / 304	5	5	Method spin-off only	Verify
Financial Analysts Journal	3	2.7 / 168	7	3	Practitioner version	Verify
Journal of Financial Data Science	3	0.7 / 21	6	2	Practitioner ML version	None known
Journal of Portfolio Management	3	0.8 / 116	6	2	Practitioner	None known
Mathematical Finance	2	1.6 / 129	2	5	Not recommended	-
Journal of Computational Finance	2	0.7 / 57	4	3	Not recommended (except numerical variant)	-
ACM ICAIF	ML	n/a	5	2	Early feedback on ML components	Varies

Full detail (scope, typical methodology, empirical/theory/data expectations, related papers, notes) is in Workbook 2.

3. What Differentiates Papers That Get In

Based on the precedents in our literature matrix [[inference from reading the published papers against working papers and practitioner outlets](#)]:

1. **An economic question, not a model.** GKX2020 asked where ML gains come from (nonlinear interactions). ACM2023 asked whether ML survives economic restrictions. JKMP2026 asked what the right evaluation criterion is (the implementable frontier). DMNU2020 asked why many characteristics matter under costs (netting).
2. **A controlled comparison.** The same data, universe and evaluation across methods, with strong linear and naive baselines.
3. **Implementability.** Costs, turnover, capacity and universe restrictions are now baseline expectations for investment claims (Novy-Marx & Velikov, 2016; Detzel, Novy-Marx & Velikov, 2023; Jensen et al., 2026).
4. **Integrity.** Transparent trial counts, out-of-sample discipline, multiple-testing awareness (Harvey, Liu & Zhu, 2016; Harvey, 2017), and increasingly reproducibility packages (JF, RFS, MS policies verified above).
5. **Interpretation.** An explanation of which signals and states drive results, tied to known economics (limits to arbitrage, sentiment, liquidity).
6. **Positioning.** Explicit statements of what is new relative to the closest papers, with no over-claiming.

4. Reviewer Expectations by Dimension

Dimension	Top-3 finance	JFQA / MS / RAPS	QF / JFM / JBF / JEF
Novelty	Conceptual contribution to finance	Clear methodological or empirical advance	Solid incremental contribution acceptable
Theory	Mechanism strongly preferred	Economic motivation; formal theory optional	Optional
Economic interpretation	Essential	Essential	Expected
Robustness	Very extensive (subperiods, universes, international, alternative specs)	Extensive	Moderate-extensive
Transaction costs	Essential for investment claims	Essential	Expected
Out-of-sample	Essential, with genuine holdout	Essential	Essential
Data	CRSP/Compustat full history; international a plus	Same	Same or narrower
Code/data	Required at acceptance	Required (MS Data Editor)	Journal-specific

5. Submission Strategy (proposed)

- Pre-submission (months 12-15).** Post an SSRN working paper with the replication code structure described. Submit to AFA, WFA, EFA, SFS Cavalcade, NBER Asset Pricing / Big Data and ML, SoFiE, FMA, and practitioner forums (Q-Group, INQUIRE). Present ML components at ICAIF for feedback. Incorporate discussant comments before journal submission.
- First journal submission.** RFS if the attribution yields a clear, general economic lesson, for example that cost-aware learning, not model complexity, drives net value and that state dependence matters only with costs internalised, backed by mechanism evidence. Otherwise go directly to **JFQA** or **Management Science**.
- After rejection.** Revise using reports, re-run the closest-prior-art check, then JFQA <-> MS, RAPS or Review of Finance, then Quantitative Finance, JFM, JBF or JEF.
- Spin-offs** (only after the main paper is public): a practitioner FAJ/JFDS article on "what matters net of costs"; a methods paper (differentiable cost-aware layers) for MS/OR/EJOR; an inference note (factorial attribution with SPA/MCS) for JFEc.
- Cover letter.** Name the closest papers explicitly (JKMP2026, SWZ2023, DMNU2020, DMU2024, ACM2023, CHK2024) and state the incremental contribution in one sentence each.

6. What Makes a Quantitative Finance Paper Publishable or Rejectable

Publishable: a sharply posed economic question; a design that isolates the answer; strong baselines including naive and linear; net-of-cost and capacity evidence; out-of-sample holdout; data-snooping controls; interpretation tied to economic theory; honest limits; a reproducible package.

Common rejection reasons (inference from field norms and the published critiques in Harvey, Liu & Zhu (2016); Harvey, 2017; Avramov, Cheng & Metzker, 2023; Chen, Hanauer & Kalsbach, 2024):

- Gross-of-cost results or unrealistic costs.
- Look-ahead bias: accounting data not lagged, survivorship, unadjusted delistings (Shumway, 1997), smoothed regime labels.
- Hyperparameter tuning on the test period; undisclosed trial counts.
- Weak benchmarks, or benchmarks under-tuned relative to the proposed model.
- Microcap-driven results with equal weighting (Hou, Xue & Zhang, 2020).
- "Black box" with no economic interpretation.
- Over-claimed novelty relative to closest papers.
- Short samples or a single market regime.
- Statistical significance claims without HAC errors, Sharpe-difference tests or multiple-testing corrections.

7. Reviewer-Proof Checklist

The full checklist is maintained in 07_Experimental_Framework/Reviewer_Proof_Checklist.md and reproduced in the Final Blueprint PDF.

Reviewer-Proof Checklist

Tick every item before submission, and record where the evidence lives (table, figure, appendix or code path). Items are derived from the published critiques and standards cited in this package (Harvey, Liu & Zhu, 2016; Harvey, 2017; Arnott, Harvey & Markowitz, 2019; Avramov, Cheng & Metzker, 2023; Chen, Hanauer & Kalsbach, 2024; Menkveld et al., 2024; Jensen et al., 2026) and from journal code/data policies (JF, RFS, MS, verified).

A. Contribution and positioning

- ☐ The research question is stated in one sentence as an economic question, not a model description.
- ☐ The contribution statement names the closest papers (JKMP2026, SWZ2023, DMNU2020, DMU2024, GKX2020, ACM2023, CHK2024, LMNS2025) and says what is new relative to each.
- ☐ The closest-prior-art tracker has been re-run within 2 weeks of submission (SSRN, NBER, arXiv, conference programmes, forward citations).
- ☐ No "first to" claim appears unless the tracker supports it.
- ☐ The hypotheses were pre-registered (dated document or OSF/AEA registry) before the lockbox was opened.
- ☐ Null or negative results are reported, with power discussion.

B. Data and point-in-time integrity

- ☐ All data sources, pull dates and versions are documented.
- ☐ Accounting variables are lagged by availability (≥ 4 months annual; RDQ quarterly) and unit tests prove it.
- ☐ Universe formed at t from all live securities (no survivorship).
- ☐ CRSP delisting returns are applied; the convention for missing values is documented.
- ☐ Corporate actions are handled via CRSP adjustment factors and total returns.
- ☐ Microcaps are excluded from the main universe; results including them are in robustness.
- ☐ Macro/state variables use real-time (vintage) data or market-based measures; no smoothed regime probabilities.
- ☐ Rebuilt standard factors correlate > 0.95 with the Ken French library.
- ☐ Signal replication statistics versus Chen-Zimmermann/JKP are reported.
- ☐ Missing-data handling is described, with robustness to imputation methods (Bryzgalova et al., 2025; Freyberger et al., 2025).

C. Validation and leakage

- ☐ Walk-forward splits, refit schedule, embargo and purging are documented in a split calendar.
- ☐ No hyperparameter is tuned on test data; the validation windows strictly precede test years.
- ☐ Lockbox period (2021-2025) opened once, after the specification freeze; the freeze date is recorded.
- ☐ Every configuration tried is logged (count reported in the paper).
- ☐ Label overlap for multi-month horizons is purged.
- ☐ NN results report dispersion across ≥ 10 seeds.

D. Benchmarks

- ☐ Naive composites (EW, theme-EW, IC-weighted, ICIR-weighted, inverse-vol) are included.
- ☐ Linear baselines (Lewellen FM, ridge, ENet, PLS) are included.
- ☐ Strongest published implementable benchmarks are included (JKMP Portfolio-ML from authors' code; DMNU linear PPP).
- ☐ Benchmarks receive the same tuning budget and cost model as proposed cells.
- ☐ $1/N$ and market portfolios are reported (DeMiguel, Garlappi & Uppal, 2009).
- ☐ Heuristic cost mitigation (banding) is compared (Novy-Marx & Velikov, 2016).

E. Portfolio construction, costs and capacity

- ☐ Net-of-cost results are primary; gross results are secondary.
- ☐ Cost model components (spread, impact, commission, borrow) and calibration sources are stated.
- ☐ Sensitivity to cost multipliers ($0.5\times-3\times$) and alternative spread estimators is shown.
- ☐ AUM grid and break-even AUM (capacity) are reported.
- ☐ Turnover, holding period and cost drag are reported for every strategy.
- ☐ Constraint set (neutralities, position/trade/participation limits) is identical across cells.
- ☐ Execution lag (≥ 1 trading day) is enforced.
- ☐ Short-leg contribution and borrow-cost treatment are disclosed.
- ☐ Long-only variant reported.

F. Statistical inference

- ☐ HAC (Newey-West) t-stats for means and alphas.
- ☐ Sharpe-ratio differences tested with Ledoit-Wolf (2008) bootstrap.
- ☐ Nested forecast comparisons with Clark-West; others with Diebold-Mariano.
- ☐ SPA and Reality Check versus the strongest benchmark; StepM for which cells win; MCS reported.
- ☐ Deflated Sharpe ratio uses the logged trial count; PBO via CSCV reported.
- ☐ Factorial effects and Shapley attributions have bootstrap confidence intervals.
- ☐ Alphas versus FF5+UMD, q5 and JKP themes (net of costs).
- ☐ Multiple theme/signal claims are FDR-controlled.
- ☐ Non-standard errors across the pre-declared multiverse are reported.

G. Robustness

- ☐ Subperiods, including pre/post decimalisation and post-2008.
- ☐ Universes: all stocks, ex-micro, top-500.
- ☐ Horizons and rebalancing frequency.
- ☐ Risk-model alternatives.
- ☐ Rolling vs expanding windows.
- ☐ Placebo (shuffled) states.
- ☐ Publication-gated signal library.
- ☐ International (developed ex-US) evidence or a stated reason for exclusion.
- ☐ Hyperparameter perturbations.

H. Economic interpretation

- ☐ Economic feature importance (net utility loss from dropping themes).
- ☐ SHAP/ALE interpretation for prediction cells, with correlated-feature caveats.
- ☐ Implied state-dependent weights are linked to DM2016, SYY2012 and CDS2020 predictions.
- ☐ Limits-to-arbitrage tilts (IVOL, illiquidity, size, distress) by cell.
- ☐ A clear answer to "why does it work (or fail)?" appears in the introduction.

I. Reproducibility and presentation

- ☐ Replication package: code, environment file, README, pseudo-data for licensed inputs (JF/RFS/MS policies).
- ☐ Figures readable in grayscale; tables have units and sample periods.
- ☐ The abstract states net-of-cost results and the holdout period.
- ☐ Internet appendix contains all robustness tables referenced.

- **Limitations** section covers cost-model uncertainty, US focus, and data licences.

Appendix. Journal Profiles

Journal	Scope	Typical methodology	Empirical expectations	Theory	Notes
Journal of Finance	All areas of finance; publishes the field's most general contributions in asset pricing and investments.	Economically motivated empirical designs, often with a model or clear economic mechanism; ML accepted when...	Very long samples (decades), CRSP/Compustat standard, extensive robustness, international or out-of-sample...	Not strictly required, but a mechanism or theoretical framing strongly...	Fit only if the paper delivers a general economic insight (e.g., where ML value comes from and why) rather than a...
Review of Financial Studies	Broad financial economics; strong record in empirical asset pricing and ML (Gu-Kelly-Xiu 2020; JKMP 2026).	Rigorous empirical asset pricing; ML papers must show economic content and robustness.	Comprehensive samples, strong baselines, transaction costs expected for investment claims, replication...	Helpful; an economic framework or model of why the effect exists is expected...	Most natural top-3 home for an implementability/decomposition paper given GKX2020, DMNU2020 and JKMP2026 precedents.
Journal of Financial Economics	Financial economics broadly; empirical and theoretical.	Economic mechanism-driven empirical work.	Long samples, identification of economic channel, robustness.	Mechanism expected.	Less natural for methods-heavy portfolio construction papers than RFS/MS.
Journal of Financial and Quantitative Analysis	Verified (jfq.org): theoretical and empirical research in financial economics, including investments, capital and security markets, and...	Rigorous empirical and quantitative methods; explicitly welcomes quantitative methods.	Comparable to top-3 in rigor; somewhat narrower contribution acceptable.	Not required for empirical methods papers with clear economic implications.	Best realistic high-quality target: quantitative methods mandate plus finance audience.
Management Science	Management broadly; Finance department publishes empirical asset pricing and ML (Chen-Pelger-Zhu 2024; Avramov-Cheng-Metzker 2023).	Methodological innovation with managerial/economic relevance; interdisciplinary ML/OR welcome.	Strong out-of-sample and robustness; replication package reviewed.	Not required; methodological or economic insight required.	Strong fit for a design that bridges ML, optimisation and finance.
Review of Finance	General finance (European Finance Association journal).	General finance standards.	High.	Helpful.	OpenAlex search did not return this title cleanly; verify metrics.
Review of Asset Pricing Studies	Asset pricing (SFS field journal).	Asset-pricing empirical and theory.	High.	Helpful.	Good home for factor-timing / signal-efficacy concepts.
Operations Research	OR methods incl. financial engineering; robust and data-driven optimisation.	Novel optimisation/learning methodology with guarantees.	Computational experiments; finance data used as application.	Usually expected (algorithms, guarantees).	Only for the differentiable/robust optimiser concept with theoretical results.
Quantitative Finance	Interdisciplinary quantitative finance; aims list includes portfolio management, market dynamics and prediction, trading systems,...	Quantitative/mathematical methods with empirical validation.	Moderate-to-high; costs expected for trading claims.	Welcome, not mandatory.	Third-party sites report a 2025 JIF around 1.9 (unverified; check JCR).
Journal of Financial Econometrics	Financial econometrics.	Econometric rigor; inference emphasis.	High for inference.	Econometric theory valued.	Fits if inference framework (SPA/MCS for decomposition) is a core contribution.
Journal of Econometrics	Econometric methodology.	New econometric methods with theory.	Application.	Required.	Needs formal econometric contribution.
Journal of Business & Economic Statistics	Applied statistics and econometrics.	Statistical methods with applications.	Moderate.	Often.	
International Journal of Forecasting	Forecasting methods and evaluation, incl. forecast combination.	Forecast evaluation rigor; combination methods.	Moderate-high.	Optional.	Fits a dynamic forecast-combination paper; must still show economic value.

Journal	Scope	Typical methodology	Empirical expectations	Theory	Notes
European Journal of Operational Research	OR incl. financial modelling and portfolio optimisation.	OR/ML methods with finance applications.	Moderate; transaction costs increasingly expected.	Optional.	Good for optimisation-heavy variants.
Journal of Banking & Finance	Finance and banking broadly, incl. investments.	Empirical finance.	High.	Optional.	
Journal of Empirical Finance	Empirical finance and financial econometrics.	Empirical/econometric.	High.	Optional.	
Journal of Financial Markets	Market microstructure, trading, asset pricing.	Empirical microstructure / trading.	High for cost modelling.	Optional.	Natural home if transaction-cost modelling is central.
Journal of Economic Dynamics and Control	Computational economics and finance.	Computational/empirical.	Moderate-high.	Optional.	
Critical Finance Review	Critical/replication-oriented finance research.	Replication, critique, careful re-examination.	High transparency.	Optional.	
Mathematical Finance	Mathematical finance theory.	Mathematical theory.	Low.	Required.	Poor fit for empirical signal combination.
Journal of Computational Finance	Verified (risk.net): numerical and computational techniques in pricing, hedging and risk management; recent issues include ML and...	Numerical methods.	Low-moderate.	Numerical analysis.	Editor-in-chief: Christoph Reisinger (risk.net).
Annals of Operations Research	OR applications incl. finance.	OR/ML.	Moderate.	Optional.	
Financial Analysts Journal	Practitioner-relevant investment research.	Rigorous but accessible.	Practical relevance, costs, capacity.	Not required.	Shorter practitioner spin-off of the main paper.
Journal of Portfolio Management	Practitioner portfolio management.	Practitioner.	Moderate.	No.	
Journal of Financial Data Science	Data science and ML in finance for practitioners.	Applied ML.	Moderate.	No.	
ACM ICAIF (conference)	Verified: ACM International Conference on AI in Finance, proceedings in ACM DL (2020-2025; 2026 in Milan).	AI/ML methods.	Benchmarks; costs often lighter.	Optional.	Useful for feedback on ML components; limited weight for finance hiring/promotion.
NeurIPS / ICML / KDD (main or workshops)	General ML; finance appears in applications and workshops.	ML novelty.	ML benchmarks.	Often.	Finance reviewers discount these unless economic evaluation is rigorous.
Expert Systems with Applications	Applied intelligent systems.	Applied ML.	Variable; costs often omitted.	No.	High citation counts do not translate into finance-field reputation; illustrates why IF alone is misleading.

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